



The Moon Points Back

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Print publication date: 2015

Print ISBN-13: 9780190226862

Published to Oxford Scholarship Online: August 2015

DOI: 10.1093/acprof:oso/9780190226862.001.0001

Relativism in Buddhist Philosophy

Candrakīrti on Mutual Dependence and the Basis of Convention

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DOI:10.1093/acprof:oso/9780190226862.003.0010

Abstract and Keywords

This chapter considers the Madhyamika claim that knowledge is merely conventional or relative (*saṃvṛti*). In his *Prasannapadā*, Candrakīrti and an unnamed interlocutor (whose position closely resembles that of Dignāga) debate the nature of the knowledge provided by perception. The importance of the dialogue is that it illustrates (via the case of perception) the mutual dependence of the means to knowledge (*pramāṇa*) and the objects of knowledge (*prameya*). The chapter develops an interpretation of the dialogue which explains how Candrakīrti can see knowledge as (merely) relative to convention, whilst also taking knowledge to function as a norm governing rational inquiry. It does this by explaining how and why Candrakīrti's relativistic conception of knowledge differs from "anything goes" relativism (the claim that all epistemic systems are equally valid). The chapter concludes that Candrakīrti's relativistic construal of knowledge is compatible with the view that knowledge is a norm of assertion governing rational inquiry.

Keywords: Candrakīrti, Dignāga, convention, epistemic warrant, perception, *pramāṇa*, relativism

IN THIS CHAPTER¹ I consider what it means for knowledge to be conventional (*saṃvṛti*), approaching the question through the lens of the Indian Buddhist philosopher Candrakīrti (c. 580–660 CE). Candrakīrti's work is important not only because of its centrality in the Madhyamaka canon and the Tibetan commentarial tradition, but also because it appears during what may be termed the "epistemological turn" in Indian philosophy.² During this period the Buddhist

logician and epistemologist Dignāga (c. 480–540 CE), followed by his successor Dharmakīrti (c. 600–660 CE), enunciated the first systematic theory of knowledge to appear within Buddhist thought. For this reason, from the time of Dignāga onwards, we see a growing tendency within Madhyamaka philosophy to frame discussions about the nature of reality in accordance with the epistemological lexicon popularized by Dignāga and his successors.³ Candrakīrti's work, then, provides a way to enter into Buddhist debates about the nature and possibility of knowledge.

One of the most interesting and perhaps initially troubling aspects of Candrakīrti's thought is his strict adherence to a global antirealism which denies that entities might exist independently of human conventions.⁴ A frequently raised criticism is that endorsing global antirealism flattens the normative role of knowledge. Indeed, as Tom Tillemans notes, **(p.221)** Candrakīrti appears to invite this very criticism when he endorses the following passage from the *Ratnakūṭa*:

The world (*loka*) argues with me. I don't argue with the world. What is agreed upon (*saṃmata*) in the world to exist, I too agree that it exists. What is agreed upon in the world to be non-existent, I too agree that it does not exist.⁵

The concern is not only the implication in the passage that “nothing the world ever endorsed could be criticized or rejected, and that, on the conventional [level] at least, a Mādhyamika's principal epistemic task [is] just to passively acquiesce and duplicate” (Tillemans 2011c, 151–152). It is also that it might look like this is the only reasonable way to understand the Mādhyamika, who claims that we lack a convention-independent standard from which to assess the epistemic status of conventional knowledge. If we accept this line of reasoning, the unfortunate conclusion is that knowledge for the Mādhyamika is less a norm governing rational inquiry and more a shorthand for what counts as knowledge relative to common agreement. And this leaves the Mādhyamika bereft of any principled way to arbitrate disputes amongst parties who disagree on the epistemic status of particular knowledge claims. Resorting to majority vote, for instance, is surely an inadequate approach.

A similar charge is often laid against that variety of relativist who thinks that the epistemic status of belief as justified or unjustified is relative to the epistemic system one happens to accept.⁶ Maria Baghramian (2004, 175), for instance, writes:

One standard criticism of relativism is that it leads to nihilism, that it abandons any serious attempt to separate good cognitive strategies from bad ones, and hence “anything goes.” Once we agree that there can be no external criterion for adjudicating between incompatible modes of

reasoning, then epistemic anarchy would loom large and we might as well give up on any pretensions to having norms of reasoning.

The suggestion in this passage is that the epistemic relativist must give up the pretense of adhering to the sorts of norms which govern the process of rational inquiry. Following John Hawthorne, we may understand **(p.222)** knowledge as one such norm. Hawthorne (2004, 23) describes knowledge as a norm of assertion insofar as “the practice of assertion is constituted by the rule/requirement that one assert something only if one knows it.”⁷ Furthermore, knowledge is a norm of reasoning insofar as reasoning is guided by those premises we take ourselves to know with at least some degree of certainty (rather than those we take to be false, or those of which we are entirely uncertain). It is plausible to take such norms to undergird rational inquiry insofar as rational inquiry proceeds via acts of assertion and acts of reasoning. To deny that knowledge is normative in this sense, then, is to threaten the possibility of rational inquiry itself.

It is worth noting that it is difficult to find an earnest defender of “anything goes” relativism in recent literature. More specifically, it is easier to find defenders of the view that justification is relative than it is to find defenders of the view that justification is relative *who also think* that this implies the arbitrariness of norms and the impossibility of rational inquiry.⁸ Most often, “anything goes” relativism is invoked either to mark a contrast with a more moderate relativism, or to gesture at an unhappy consequence awaiting those who do not heed the warnings of realists and/or foundationalists. In my view, the interesting task is for the moderate relativist to defend their view by clearly distinguishing it from the straw man (the “anything goes” relativist). The same goes for Candrakīrti.

In what is to come, I argue that, though there is indeed a sense in which Candrakīrti appears to endorse the view that conventional knowledge is simply that which is relative to our conventions, this does not imply that such conventions are arbitrary and lacking in rational basis. Conventional knowledge depends on human convention, but it is normative in a manner robust enough to support rational inquiry. In support of this view I focus on a dialogue which appears in the first chapter of *Prasannapadā*, in which Candrakīrti engages in debate concerning the nature of conventional knowledge with an unnamed interlocutor whose position closely resembles that of Dignāga.⁹ In section 10.1 of the chapter, I provide an interpretation of the dialogue, focusing on Candrakīrti’s reasons for rejecting his interlocutor’s construal of perception and its object. In section 10.2, I introduce a classical formulation of epistemic relativism which denies the normativity of knowledge. I then argue that Candrakīrti’s construal of conventional knowledge as evidenced in the dialogue is incompatible with the classical formulation. In section 10.3, I consider what this analysis tells us about the nature and basis of conventional knowledge itself. I argue that the debate

between Candrakīrti and his interlocutor concerning the nature **(p.223)** of perception is important because it illustrates how we should understand the mutual dependence of the means to knowledge (*pramāṇa*) and the objects of knowledge (*prameya*),¹⁰ and suggest that it is this two-way dependence relation which itself allows for the normativity of knowledge at the conventional level.

10.1 Candrakīrti on Perception and the Object of Perception

In the dialogue, Candrakīrti attempts to show that his interlocutor's *pramāṇa* theory is unable to explain the nature and basis of conventional epistemic practice. Dignāga's *pramāṇa* theory posits two sorts of reliable warrant (*pramāṇa*), which yield knowledge of two kinds of warrantable object (*prameya*).¹¹ The two reliable warrants are perception (*pratyakṣa*) and inference (*anumāna*), epistemic faculties which provide knowledge of, respectively, the particular (*svalakṣaṇa*) and the universal (*sāmānyalakṣaṇa*). The former is held to be an ultimate real, whilst the latter has only conventional existence. The particular, described by Dignāga in his *Pramāṇasammucaya* as that "indefinable form which is to be known in itself,"¹² is an entity about which nothing may properly be predicated.¹³ In contrast, the universal, a product of the mind's facility for conceptual construction (*kalpanā*), is something which is constitutively "definable," where that which is definable is that which has structure, and where structure may be described as follows: "What kind of thing is this so-called structure? *Attaching a name, a universal and so forth.*" In contrast, perception is defined as "that in which this structure is not present."¹⁴ It is in virtue of this lack of structure that perception, for Dignāga, is understood to operate without the mediation of concepts.

Candrakīrti objects to this construal of perception at the conventional level, stating that "this [characterization of *pratyakṣa* as 'devoid of conceptual elaboration'] does not make sense" (Arnold 2005a, 460). For Candrakīrti, this follows from observation of everyday language conventions (certainly the place to start for an account of what specifically *conventional* knowledge consists in). Though Dignāga claims that the term *pratyakṣa* primarily serves to pick out an epistemic faculty (that of perception), Candrakīrti holds that it is in fact the adjectival sense of *pratyakṣa*, meaning "perceptible," that is primary in everyday locutions.¹⁵ That is, though it is through such ordinary locutions as "The jar is perceptible"¹⁶ **(p.224)** that we might *derive* the idea of that cognitive faculty we call "perception," we do not *begin* with such an idea and consequently derive the notion of perceptibility. For Candrakīrti, then, Dignāga's construal of *pratyakṣa* as "perception" is an unnecessarily technical derivation which is inconsistent with everyday language use.¹⁷ Now, if all this is so, then Dignāga cannot be correct in claiming that the object of perception must be "devoid of conceptual elaboration." This is because what the faculty of perception cognizes is just that which is described as perceptible in everyday discourse:

Therefore, in the world, if *any* (*sarvam eva*) subject of characterisation (*lakṣya*)—whether it be a *svalakṣaṇa* or a *sāmānyalakṣaṇa*—is visible, because of being directly apprehended, then it is established as perceptible, along with the cognition that has it as its object [which is derivatively called “*pratyakṣa*”].

(Arnold 2005a, 460–461)

Candrakīrti here expresses the view that any *lakṣya* which may be characterized in some way or another (that is, any x which fits the basic logical paradigm expressed by Fx where F is a predicate applied to some x) and is visible, is that which we call perceptible, and is that which is cognized via the faculty of perception. There is warrant to take Candrakīrti to here be asserting that perception is concept-laden at the conventional level. This interpretation is supported by the following factors. First, in the quotation Candrakīrti describes the *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* or universal, the paradigm of a conceptually constructed entity, as perceptible. Second, in describing the *svalakṣaṇa* as perceptible, Candrakīrti appears to revert to the traditional usage of the term, according to which it denotes the “defining characteristic” of a thing (such as the earth’s hardness).¹⁸ In this sense, *svalakṣaṇas* are, constitutively, things which are characterized in some way or another. That is, they are things which are encountered *under a description* and thereby require the mediation of concepts.

Candrakīrti also claims that, if any object of perception is “visible, because of being directly apprehended, then it is established as perceptible” (Arnold 2005a, 460). Here, Candrakīrti seems to state that it is sufficient to establish some object x as perceptible if it is visible in the sense of being apprehended directly. Candrakīrti expands upon this definition as follows:

Twin moons and other such [illusions] do not, from the point of view of the cognition of one without cataracts, have the quality of being **(p.225)** perceptible (*apratyakṣatvam*)—although from the point of view of one with cataracts, [such illusions] have precisely the quality of being perceptible.

(Arnold 2005a: 461)

In this quotation Candrakīrti appears to draw a distinction between what is perceptible for a cognizer with cataracts and what is perceptible for a cognizer without cataracts by basing that which is “perceptible” on what seems to be the case, given each cognizer’s respective point of view. For the cognizer with cataracts, it seems that there is a twin moon and therefore, for this cognizer, the twin moon has the quality of being perceptible. For the cognizer without cataracts, it does not seem that there is a twin moon and therefore, for this cognizer, the twin moon does not have the quality of being perceptible. This suggests that, for Candrakīrti, what is “perceptible” at the conventional level is simply that which appears before one, regardless of whether it is, finally, a

cognition which accurately or inaccurately cognizes its object. This suggests that Candrakīrti endorses the view that a cognizer *S* has warrant for holding something to be perceptible so long as it *seems* to be perceptible. This itself suggests the following principle, which represents one way of understanding the nature of the warrant Candrakīrti may take perception to provide at the level of the conventional, given the evidence just presented in the dialogue (for ease of reference I refer to this principle as “Candrakīrti’s principle” or *CP* for short):

If it appears to *S* that *p*, *S* has prima facie warrant for that cognitive episode which may be expressed via the linguistic utterance *p*.

This principle delineates the circumstances under which one has warrant for the validity of a cognitive episode whose truth-evaluable content may be expressed via the linguistic utterance *p*. The appropriateness of taking this principle to be a rational reconstruction of Candrakīrti’s view, however, requires qualification. Firstly, note that *CP* makes reference to cognitive episodes rather than beliefs to reflect the episodic rather than dispositional nature of knowledge in Indian philosophy. A *pramāṇa* is typically construed as providing warrant for a cognitive episode rather than a belief. Nonetheless, the two are certainly related insofar as the content of both may be expressed via use of assertoric linguistic utterances. Secondly, note that *CP* makes reference to “prima facie” warrant rather than warrant *simpliciter*. The idea here is that the principle should express Candrakīrti’s seeming endorsement of the view that what *appears* (**p. 226**) to be perceptible for a given cognizer *S* is the basis upon which we define what *is* perceptible for them at the conventional level, without concurrently suggesting that this will always *guarantee* the conventional truth of a given cognitive episode.

This second qualification concerns the relationship between truth and warrant and is worth considering in more detail. Candrakīrti’s “twin moons” example might be thought, at first glance, to provide a relativistic construal of conventional truth, for it perhaps suggests that the conventional truth of whether or not there is a twin moon depends merely upon the perspective of the individual cognizer. I would argue that this interpretation is too quick. In the quoted example, Candrakīrti relativizes what is conventionally called “perceptible” to the perspective of an individual cognizer, but he does not suggest that conventional truth (*saṃvṛtisatya*) is itself relative to the perspective of an individual cognizer. To be able to attribute this latter, stronger claim to Candrakīrti, we would need to have reason to think that perceptibility in the sense here described straightforwardly entails the conventional truth of what is perceived. Though it is not within the scope of this chapter to argue against this stronger claim, there are alternative ways of construing this relationship. In his interpretation of Candrakīrti, Arnold (2005b, 52), for instance, invokes Frege’s distinction between how we come to know the truth of something and what it is in virtue of which it is true; whilst a *pramāṇa* is a necessary condition for

conventionally valid knowledge, it is not in itself a sufficient condition for truth. Rather, it is properly seen as that which provides us with an *entitlement* to think of something as true. In this way, warrant does not necessarily assure one of truth.¹⁹ Jay Garfield (2010, 35) approaches the issue in a different way, defining the conventional truth of a conventionally valid cognition as “that which is delivered by unimpaired cognitive faculties when they are used properly.” For Garfield, this definition is “not an accidental generalisation; instead it is *constitutive* of conventional truth” (2010, 35). The suggestion is as follows: that which is delivered by *impaired* cognitive faculties, or by unimpaired cognitive faculties which are not being used properly, is *not* conventional truth. For instance, if one is suffering from jaundice or is operating under the influence of hallucinogens, one’s perceptual cognitions should not be trusted to assure one of conventional truth. It is perhaps ambiguous here as to whether, in these situations, use of a genuine, conventionally reliable *pramāṇa* fails to provide conventional truth, or whether it is instead that what looks like a genuine, conventionally reliable *pramāṇa* is, in fact, untrustworthy and therefore not a genuine **(p.227)** *pramāṇa* after all. Nonetheless, either interpretation supports the view that Candrakīrti need not be understood as committed to the view that what appears perceptible to a given cognizer always entails the conventional truth of that which is perceived.

We are now in a position to contrast *CP* with Dignāga’s construal of perception. In the dialogue, Candrakīrti’s interlocutor claims that it is “figuratively” (*upacāra*) rather than “literally” the case that everyday compound objects are perceptible:

just as it is taught that “the birth of buddhas is bliss”—[an expression that is understood as] involving figurative reference to the effect with respect to [what is really] the cause—in the same way, a jar, even though occasioned by perceptibles like its colour, is designated as “perceptible,” making a figurative reference to the cause with respect to [what is really] the effect.

(Arnold 2005a: 450)

Mark Siderits here interprets Candrakīrti’s interlocutor as taking the teaching “The birth of buddhas is bliss” to be a figurative expression because it is not the birth of the Buddha itself which is blissful, but rather the results “produced by the career of the Buddha” which result in bliss.²⁰ That is, the statement can be understood as a classic case of *kāraṇe kāryopacāra*, in which there is a figurative or metaphorical transference of the property *bliss* to what is the cause of bliss, rather than its effect. It is in this sense that the claim “The birth of buddhas is bliss” is “figuratively” and not literally the case.

The interlocutor takes this example to be analogous to everyday statements pertaining to perceptual objects, such as “The jar is perceptible.” One way to understand the interlocutor’s intention here is as an attempt to justify his aforementioned claim that *pratyakṣa* refers primarily to perception. That is, it is an attempt to claim that in everyday discourse we “figuratively” characterize the jar as *pratyakṣa* (that is, as perceptible) *because* it is cognized by that cognitive faculty properly known as *pratyakṣa* (that is, as perception). Candrakīrti is dismissive of this attempt and considers another interpretation, according to which his interlocutor is pointing out that the jar is in fact a compound object whose existence depends on its parts, and it is these parts which are perceived rather than the jar itself. Here, there is a figurative application of the property *perceptible* to the effect (the jar), rather than the cause (the genuinely perceptible jar-parts). In this way, there is a cause and effect metaphorical transference just as (p.228) in the “birth of buddhas” example. This is another reason Candrakīrti’s interlocutor wants to hold that statements like “The jar is perceptible” can be the case only in a manner of speaking.

If we accept this analogy then we can perhaps express the nature of the warrant provided by Candrakīrti’s interlocutor as follows (I refer to this principle as “Dignāga’s principle,” or *DP* for short):

If it appears to *S* that *p*, *S* has warrant for the cognitive episode expressed via the linguistic utterance “*p* is figuratively the case.”

Further support for taking this principle to adequately represent Candrakīrti’s understanding of Dignāga’s account of perception is provided by Candrakīrti’s critique of Dignāga’s *svalakṣaṇa* (the object of perception). As mentioned previously, Dignāga holds perception to be that epistemic faculty whose proper object is the particular, defined as that ineffable object about which nothing may properly be predicated. Perception, then, is that epistemic faculty which perceives objects that cannot be described or characterized in any way whatsoever. This suggests that *DP* could, at best, provide warrant for a statement like “The jar is brown” as figuratively rather than literally the case, for, literally speaking, the “jar” itself cannot be described nor characterized. This principle, then, would seem to provide warrant of an unusual sort. Perceptual experience does not provide warrant for *p simpliciter*, where *p* stands for a knowledge claim concerning perceptual experience. Instead, perceptual experience provides warrant for *p* insofar as *p* is taken to be figuratively and not literally the case.

Having said this, I would caution that while I do take *DP* to be an accurate characterization of Candrakīrti’s interlocutor in the dialogue, I make no claim to be representing the position held by the historical Dignāga. The point here, after all, is not about whether it is Cāndrakīrti or Dignāga who has the more respectable position. Rather, the focus is on what Candrakīrti’s criticisms of his

interlocutor tell us about his own understanding of conventional knowledge. For this reason, *DP* is better understood as an expression of what Candrakīrti finds objectionable in his interlocutor's position (as he understands it), not as a charitable reconstruction of Dignāga's view.

With this expression of the differences between *CP* and *DP*, we are now in a position to consider the basis upon which Candrakīrti takes *CP* to be preferable to *DP*. There are at least two main reasons suggested in the dialogue. The first is the fact that *DP* contravenes conventional (p.229) epistemic practice. As we have just seen, *DP* grants warrant for knowledge claims which have merely figurative value. This is problematic because a statement which we may only think of as true in a figurative sense is, by implication, false when taken literally. And, in conventional epistemic practice, such statements as "The jar is brown" are not taken to be true when understood figuratively. Rather, they are simply taken to be true.²¹

The second reason is more relevant for our purposes. The intent is to understand why Candrakīrti might have principled reason to prefer *CP* over *DP*. However, it is not enough for Candrakīrti to simply state that *CP* is preferable to *DP* because the latter is incompatible with conventional epistemic practice, for perhaps the interlocutor will reply by claiming that his intent is not so much to explain conventional epistemic practice, but to instead explain the nature of perception itself, regardless of whether or not his explanation is in conformity with convention. If met with this reply, Candrakīrti would need to provide stronger grounds for his preferencing of *CP*.

To see how Candrakīrti might respond here, it is instructive to consider his critique of Dignāga's *svalakṣaṇa*, which appears immediately prior to his critique of his interlocutor's account of perception. Candrakīrti appears to have been influenced by the *kāraṇa* analysis of the Sanskrit grammarians, according to which a prerequisite for the meaningfulness or intelligibility of any complete verbal expression is that one be able to break down the discrete components of the action described in the given expression, making reference to the subject of characterization (*lakṣya*), the characteristic (*lakṣaṇa*), and the agent responsible for making the given characterization.²² In the expression "Aristotle characterizes a life of pleasure as suitable for beasts," for example, the subject of characterization is a "life of pleasure," whilst the characteristic is that it is "suitable for beasts." The agent responsible for the characterization is Aristotle.

Consider this paradigm in relation to the ontological posits of Dignāga's epistemological typology, according to which there are only two objects of knowledge, the particular and the universal. In attempting to explain how his epistemological typology can accommodate the linguistic paradigm described above, the interlocutor claims that he may follow the Nyāya with regards to asserting the existence of a discrete subject of characterization construed as an

individual substance (*dravya*), an entity in which characteristics inhere.²³ For the Nyāya, these characteristics can be of five types: qualities, actions, universals, individuators, and inherence. **(p.230)** A universal property like *cowness* for instance, inheres in an individual cow. Candrakīrti responds by arguing that Dignāga may not accept “the categories imagined by non-Buddhists, which are devoid of arguments (*yukativadhura*),” for he would then “have to admit, as well, [their] additional [list of what count as] reliable warrants, and so forth” (Arnold 2005a, 443). This reply suggests that Dignāga may not appeal to the categories accepted by the Nyāya because they are entirely at odds with the ontological posits of his *pramāṇa* theory. This can be seen with a simple example. Whilst the Nyāya would describe a universal property like *cowness* as inhering in an individual cow, this is not an option open to Dignāga. As we have seen, Dignāga only admits of the existence of particulars and universals, and holds that universal properties (like *cowness*) do not inhere in particulars (Dreyfus 1997, 52–59).

This is problematic for Candrakīrti’s interlocutor because such categories bear an important relation to the linguistic paradigm Candrakīrti began with. The effective suggestion made by Candrakīrti seems to be that, without holding that a subject of characterization (*lakṣya*) has, as its referent, something like a substance, and that a characteristic (*lakṣaṇa*) refers to a property which *inheres* in such a substance, an expression like “The jar is brown,” in which reference is made to a subject of characterization (the jar) and a characteristic (its brown color) will be an expression which lacks meaning.

It seems, then, that the ontological posits of Dignāga’s epistemological typology preclude him from accepting the view that a subject of characterization refers to an individual substance, and that a characteristic refers to a property which may be thought to inhere such a substance. However, if this is so, then one might wonder how it is possible for Dignāga to even express the central tenets of his epistemological theory in an intelligible manner; for surely he can do so only by making use of verbal expressions in which acts of characterization occur. Perhaps this point can be seen most clearly in the fact that, if Dignāga were to state “The object of perception is a *svalakṣaṇa* which is devoid of universal properties,” he would seem to contradict himself by taking *svalakṣaṇa* to function as a subject of characterization which refers to a substance, and “devoid of universal properties” to function as a property thought to inhere in such a substance, when in fact what this statement is supposed to be telling us is that the *svalakṣaṇa* is devoid of such properties altogether, including the property of being *devoid of properties*. It would seem, then, that Dignāga commits a performative contradiction, in the sense that the propositional content **(p.231)** of his statement seems to contradict the necessary presuppositions that make performance of the speech act possible.²⁴

If we now recall *DP*, which states, “If it appears to *S* that *p*, *S* has warrant for the cognitive episode expressed via the linguistic utterance ‘*p* is figuratively the case,’ ” we can see that *DP* itself may not be asserted without the occurrence of performative contradiction. That is, Dignāga could meaningfully assert *DP* only if he were to presuppose the ontological categories whose denial the principle itself is founded upon. In this sense *DP* is logically incoherent, and it is this fact which would seem to provide Candrakīrti with principled reason in favor of preferring his own understanding of the reliable warrant which is perception over that of Dignāga. This is how the dialogue may be read as providing an understanding of what it might mean for Candrakīrti to prefer one particular construal of the reliable warrant of perception to another.

At this point, one could easily enough imagine a retort from Dignāga, who would likely argue that Candrakīrti has failed to appreciate the sophistication of his position. He could draw attention to the fact that Candrakīrti does not explicitly discuss *apoha* theory, which Dignāga employs to explain how his account remains compatible with conventional language use. For the Apohavādin, ordinary discourse does not, contra Candrakīrti, require that predicates reflect *real* universal properties in order to be meaningful. All that is required are appropriate substitutes, which Dignāga describes as (ultimately) unreal, mentally fabricated *apoha*. For instance, rather than requiring a real universal property like *red* for the statement “The apple is red” to be meaningful, we can substitute not-not-*red*, which denotes the exclusion of not-*red*, rather than *red* itself.

Candrakīrti, in turn, could respond by arguing that this counter will render Dignāga’s own theory redundant. Consider, for instance, the meaning of Dignāga’s claim “The *svalakṣaṇa* is impermanent.” For the Apohavādin, this statement translates as “The *svalakṣaṇa* is not-not-impermanent.” However, if an ascription of “not-not-*F*” to a thing means ascribing something which is ultimately a mental fabrication, then it surely follows that Dignāga’s attempts to describe the nature of the *svalakṣaṇa* amount to nothing more than a sort of fictional story, which is a problem if Dignāga’s intent was to tell us something about the way things really are.

Dignāga’s likely reply to this counter is of significance, but would require delving into an extended discussion of the relationship between conventionalism, fictionalism, and the ineffable world. For now, suffice to say that Dignāga would likely respond by arguing that his account should **(p.232)** not be understood as one which describes the nature of ultimate reality. Rather, it should be understood in context of the view that there may be a gradation of conventional truths, some of which are more profound than others. This would allow Dignāga to admit that he *is* telling us a sort of fictional story; it is just that it is a fictional story which should be understood as superior to the standard conventional view.²⁵ Nonetheless, these issues lie outside the scope of this chapter, which

chiefly concerns the understanding of conventional knowledge implicit in the dialogue at hand. In the dialogue, it is clear that Candrakīrti (who takes the notion of gradations of conventional truth as entirely unintelligible) takes Dignāga's account to be one which ultimately results in a logically incoherent attempt to explain conventional epistemic practice.

10.2 Candrakīrti and Epistemic Relativism

With this interpretation of the dialogue in mind, we may now return to the original problematic informing this piece, namely the question of whether conventional knowledge is, for Candrakīrti, unable to function as a norm governing rational inquiry. We come some way toward answering this question by considering what the interpretation of the dialogue at hand tells us about situations in which there are principled grounds for arbitrating epistemic disputes which occur at the conventional level. Rather than attempting to demonstrate that, for Candrakīrti, there are principled grounds for arbitrating *any* epistemic dispute whatsoever, the intent is to take a single step in this direction, by showing that there is reason to believe that, for Candrakīrti, there are principled grounds for arbitrating epistemic disputes *which occur between parties who accept very different sets of epistemic norms*. This focus reflects the fact that it is these sorts of disputes which tend to raise the specter of “anything goes” relativism. If two parties disagree about whether they can see a particular object far off in the distance, for instance, the basis of the dispute might simply be the fact that neither is close enough to the object to make an accurate judgment. In this case, the dispute could be resolved via both parties simply moving closer. However, if the parties disagree because one adheres to *CP* whilst the other adheres to *DP*, they might be more inclined to pronounce their dispute irresolvable, and might instead simply agree to disagree. **(p.233)**

This section begins with an outline of a classical formulation of epistemic relativism discussed in recent years by both Paul Boghossian (2006) and Michael Williams (2007). It provides a useful framework within which the nature and function of epistemic norms may be better understood. It concludes with the suggestion that the interpretation of Candrakīrti developed in section one differentiates his construal of conventional knowledge from the position adhered to by the epistemic relativist, but is not in itself sufficient to demonstrate its compatibility with the normative function of knowledge. This paves the way for the discussion in section 10.3, in which I suggest a way of reframing the debate between Candrakīrti and his interlocutor which provides firmer ground from which to argue in favor of Candrakīrti's commitment to the normative nature of knowledge at the conventional level.

Boghossian describes an “epistemic system” as that which functions to distinguish justified from unjustified belief. It is a system constituted by a set of general principles, called “epistemic principles,” which specify the conditions under which a particular type of belief will count as justified. For instance, the

judgment “Galileo is justified in believing that there are mountains on the moon if it visually seems to Galileo that there are mountains on the moon” is a belief justified by the following epistemic principle (Boghossian calls it “Observation”):

For any observational proposition *p*, if it visually seems to *S* that *p* and circumstantial conditions *D* obtain, then *S* is *prima facie* justified in believing *p*.

(Boghossian 2006, 64)

In what is to come, I use the notion of an epistemic principle and its placement within an epistemic system adhered to by a given cognizer as a way of understanding the nature and function of an epistemic norm.

As Michael Williams (2007, 106) notes, quoting Wittgenstein, epistemic principles may be understood as “judgments [used] as principles of judgment.” In this sense, epistemic principles are simply a subset of beliefs within an individual’s belief system. Nonetheless, they occupy a special place in virtue of their foundational role in jointly ensuring the credibility of all beliefs held within an individual’s belief system. Denying observation, for instance, would seem to threaten the credibility of all observational beliefs held by an individual. **(p.234)**

There are three jointly necessary and sufficient conditions which Boghossian and Williams both take the epistemic relativist to adhere to. They may be summarized as follows:

- (1) A belief’s epistemic status as justified or not is not an intrinsic property.
- (2) A belief’s epistemic status as justified or not depends upon the epistemic system the believer adheres to.
- (3) There are many fundamentally different, genuinely alternative epistemic systems, but no epistemic system is superior to any other.

The first criterion states that there are no absolute facts about what justifies what; whether some piece of evidence justifies a particular belief cannot be determined in isolation from the epistemic system one adheres to. The second criterion describes the sense in which justification is relative; a belief’s epistemic status as justified or unjustified is dependent upon, or relative to, the epistemic system the believer adheres to. The third criterion includes two components: first, the empirical claim that there are many fundamentally different, genuinely alternative epistemic systems, and second, the normative claim that no epistemic system is superior to any other.

It is not difficult to see how adherence to these criteria might commit one to a conception of knowledge which flattens its normative role. As soon as we accept the second criterion, namely that what is and is not justified depends on the

epistemic system the believer adheres to, we are faced with the threat of circularity. How can we know that the epistemic system we are using is itself justified? The epistemic system, being the only means by which to assess the credibility of belief, is the only thing that may be used to justify the principles enshrined in the system itself. However, to use the epistemic system toward this end is to presuppose the justified status of the very principles whose status as justified we are attempting to determine. Given, then, that the only justification for using our epistemic system will rely on circular reasoning, it would seem that it could not be rational to use the principles enshrined in the epistemic system in the first place (see M. Williams 2007, 94–95). Now consider the third criterion, according to which no epistemic system is superior to any other. In cases where two parties adhere to alternative epistemic systems, neither party will be able to justify their allegiance to the beliefs they hold in an objective manner, because their respective beliefs can be supported **(p.235)** only by contrary epistemic systems whose credibility may be justified only circularly. Consequently, it would seem that knowledge cannot function as a norm of rational inquiry in cases where there are disputes between proponents who accept alternative epistemic systems.

We may now consider how the interpretation developed in the previous section relates to an epistemic relativism of this sort. Following Boghossian, we may define two epistemic systems, *ES1* and *ES2*, as being genuinely alternative if they are capable of yielding conflicting verdicts on whether some knowledge claim *p* is warranted or not (see Boghossian 2006, 73). Imagine two epistemic systems which differ insofar as *ES1* accepts *CP* whilst *ES2* accepts *DP*. *CP* tells us that the knowledge claim “The jar is brown” is warranted for *S* if perceptual experience suggests to *S* that the jar is brown. In contrast, *DP* only grants that the knowledge claim “The jar is brown *in a figurative sense*” is warranted for *S* if perceptual experience suggests to *S* that the jar is brown. This is so because, for Candrakīrti’s interlocutor, the brown jar is not something which, strictly speaking, may be perceived at all. In this way, these two epistemic systems yield conflicting verdicts concerning the epistemic status of knowledge claims relating to perceptual experience. *CP* tells us that the knowledge claim “The jar is brown” is warrantable whilst *DP* tells us that it is not (after all, if it is true that the jar is brown only in a figurative sense, as *DP* suggests, it is false that the jar is brown in a literal sense). Now, as was seen in the previous section, the dialogue can be read to suggest that Candrakīrti has principled reason for taking *CP* to be superior to *DP* insofar as *DP* amounts to a denial of some of the intelligibility prerequisites of ordinary language use, and is, *ipso facto*, logically incoherent. This consequently provides principled reason for taking *ES1* to be superior to *ES2*, which itself suggests that the notion of conventional knowledge implicit in the interpretation of the dialogue here developed is not compatible with the view that *no* epistemic system is superior to any other, for there is at least *one* epistemic system (*ES1*) which is superior to another (*ES2*).

There are, however, some grounds for interpreting the dialogue as not only suggestive of the view that there is one epistemic system (*ES1*) which is superior to another (*ES2*), but also of the view that any epistemic system which adheres to a non-concept-laden account of perception is inferior to one which does not. This interpretation is plausible if we take it that part of what Candrakīrti is doing in the dialogue is pressing a relatively simple and general point: namely, that it is only an account according to which **(p.236)** conceptual content is present in perception that will be capable of making sense of conventional epistemic discourse. This rendering of Candrakīrti might take him to be making a claim along the lines of the view, expressed by Anil Gupta (2006, 7), that “what we call ‘ordinary judgments of perception’ do not issue from experience alone. They are founded in experience *and* conception.”

Support for this interpretation can be found if we notice that, in the antecedent of the conditional which makes up *CP*, reference is made to a perceptual state in which things appear to be some particular way rather than another. That is, reference is made to a perceptual state which represents things as being some particular way rather than another. In order for a perceptual state to be able to represent something in this way, however, the use of concepts is required; a prerequisite for perception to have representational content is that it have conceptual content. To perceptually experience the jar *as* being on the table, for instance, I must possess the concept *jar* and the concept *table*. This may be contrasted with a prediscursive form of perception discussed by figures like Dretske (1969), according to which one may be able, at times, to perceptually discriminate between objects and interact with one’s environment successfully (climb the stairs and open the front door, for instance) without being aware *that* one is climbing the stairs, *that* the front door is brown, and so on. The point is that *CP* itself appears to require that conceptual content be present in perception, insofar as what is perceived is determined, at the conventional level, by what appears to be perceived (which itself presupposes that in perception things appear to be some particular way rather than another, rather than no particular way at all). In this way, Candrakīrti’s construal of perception in the dialogue at hand could plausibly be read as suggesting that any adequate “epistemic principle” explaining our warrant for knowledge claims concerning perceptual experience at the conventional level must be able to account for the fact that, in ordinary discourse, perceptual experience is understood to be concept-laden. Indeed, this interpretation surely follows from Candrakīrti’s view that it simply does not make sense to take the object of perception to be an entity about which nothing may properly be predicated (i.e., Dignāga’s particular).

If this stronger interpretation has any warrant, it suggests that the dialogue not only provides principled reason for taking *DP* to be inferior to *CP*, but also reason for taking *any* epistemic principle which presupposes a non-concept-laden account of perception (along with the epistemic system of which it is a

part) to be an inferior choice. Either interpretation **(p.237)** is sufficient to distinguish Candrakīrti's view of conventional knowledge (at least insofar as it is expressed in the interpretation of the dialogue at hand) from the view adhered to by the epistemic relativist, for this analysis shows that Candrakīrti's view may not be assimilated with the third criterion adhered to by the relativist.

10.3 Relativism and Mutual Dependence

The analysis of the previous sections suggests that it would be a mistake to assimilate Candrakīrti's position with an unbridled relativism upon which all epistemic systems are of equal validity. However, we are yet to consider whether asserting as much tells us anything about whether Candrakīrti's construal of conventional knowledge in the dialogue commits the Mādhyamika to a denial of the normativity of knowledge at the conventional level. The foregoing analysis suggests that Candrakīrti, at the very least, has principled reason to prefer one epistemic system (*ES1*) over one other (*ES2*). Consider two parties, one of whom accepts *ES1* and the other of whom accepts *ES2*. Assume they disagree on the epistemic status of a knowledge claim concerning perceptual experience, and that their dispute rests on the fact that they adhere to alternative epistemic systems. In such situations, the Mādhyamika has principled reason for taking the knowledge claim warranted by *ES1* to be accepted over the knowledge claim warranted by *ES2*. If it is also true that the Mādhyamika has principled reason to reject *any* epistemic system upon which a non-concept-laden account of perception is endorsed, then the Mādhyamika would have principled reason for taking a knowledge claim concerning perceptual experience warranted by *ES1* to be accepted over a conflicting knowledge claim pertaining to any epistemic system falling into the set of those epistemic systems upon which a non-concept-laden account of perception is accepted.

However, this is not in itself sufficient to show that, for Candrakīrti, there are principled grounds for arbitrating such disputes between parties who adhere to *any* conceivable set of genuinely alternative epistemic systems. To put the point another way, it is as yet unclear whether Candrakīrti's view might have greater affinity with a milder variety of relativism, according to which some (if not all) epistemic systems are of equal validity. To illustrate this point, consider just the set of conceivable epistemic systems which adhere to *CP*. One could imagine two epistemic systems, both of which accept *CP*, but one of which yields to classical logical **(p.238)** laws concerning inference whilst the other defers to intuitionistic logic. In this instance, these two hypothetical epistemic systems might yield conflicting verdicts on knowledge claims concerning perceptual experience, but we would lack a story about how adjudication between such systems could occur. In such instances, knowledge claims pertaining to perceptual experience would, if we accept the epistemic relativist's assessment of the situation, be based on the use of epistemic systems which could be justified only circularly. The consequence would be that knowledge would, in such instances, be incapable of functioning as a norm governing rational inquiry.

For this reason, the interpretation of the dialogue here developed does not yet go as far as it would need to in order to demonstrate that Candrakīrti's construal of conventional knowledge is compatible with the normative function of knowledge.

Despite this limitation, however, a slightly different take on the dialogue may provide a stronger indication. To see this, consider that we might take the case of perception addressed in the dialogue as indicative of a more general principle; namely, that we should look to intersubjectively available objects of knowledge when we seek to resolve seemingly insoluble disputes. Consider the relativist's view that we have reason for preferencing one epistemic system over another only if noncircular justification of epistemic principles is possible. Holding that such justification is not possible, the relativist can only but conclude that all epistemic systems are of equal validity. Crucially, underlying the epistemic relativist's desire for noncircular justification is the thought that there is *no other way* we could sanction our choice of the epistemic principles we use in our day-to-day reasoning. Candrakīrti's dialogue may be read as presenting a challenge to this view.

This can be seen if we view the debate over perception as an illustration of the notion of mutual dependence. Closely following Candrakīrti's analysis in *Prasannapadā*, Tsongkhapa notes that "convention" can itself be "taken to mean mutually dependent."²⁶ In context of the study of knowledge, this claim can perhaps best be understood in reference to the Madhyamaka understanding of conventional knowledge as that which is made possible in virtue of the mutual dependence of *pramāṇa* and *prameya*. One way to understand this dependence relation is to hold that *pramāṇa* and *prameya* exist in constitutively relative fashion; what we know is, in part, determined by the way or ways in which we come to know, whilst, conversely, those means to knowledge we take to be authoritative are, in part, determined by those things we already take ourselves to know. **(p.239)**

At the conclusion of the dialogue, Candrakīrti follows his conventional endorsement of a concept-laden account of perception with a conventional endorsement of the additional *pramāṇas* of inference, tradition, and comparison.²⁷ After briefly describing each, Candrakīrti states:

Just so, everyone's understanding of things is established based on this fourfold [scheme of] reliable warrants.

And these are established in dependence upon one another: given reliable warrants, there are warrantable objects, and given warrantable objects, there are reliable warrants. But it is emphatically *not* the case that the establishment of reliable warrants and their objects is essential (*svābhāviki*). Therefore, let the mundane remain just as it is seen.

(Arnold 2005a, 462–463).

Candrakīrti here appears to suggest that it is the mutual dependence of *pramāṇa* and *prameya* that determines the respective nature of *pramāṇa* and *prameya*. It would seem plausible to argue that the reason this assertion appears toward the end of a substantive critique of Dignāga's account of perception and its object is precisely because this critique may be interpreted as an illustration of some of the problems which arise from the attempt to determine the nature of *pramāṇa* and *prameya* without prior recognition of their constitutive interdependence. As we have seen, Dignāga posits the existence of ultimate reals, in the form of particulars, along with the existence of an epistemic faculty which is able to apprehend their nature without the distorting influence of conceptual construction. In developing this account, Candrakīrti's interlocutor neither allows the conventional understanding of perception to influence his account of the particular, nor for the conventional understanding of that which is perceptible to influence his account of perception. The suggestion, then, is that one may not attempt to determine the object of perception or the nature of perception in isolation from our conventional experience of perception and its objects. Indeed, this follows from the doctrine of mutual dependence: if knowledge of *pramāṇa* depends on knowledge of *prameya*, and if knowledge of *prameya* depends on knowledge of *pramāṇa*, then the act of defining our respective *pramāṇas* and *prameyas* will always occur within a closed circle, so to speak. This in turn suggests that the attempt to provide a formal, philosophical account of the respective natures of *pramāṇa* and *prameya* cannot be understood as an enterprise in which we are describing the means and objects of knowledge which exist independently of the conventions enshrined in ordinary **(p.240)** language use and in our epistemic practices. If this is so, then perhaps my interpretation of the dialogue as providing principled reason for endorsing *CP* over *DP* in fact suggests that the former definition of that reliable warrant which is perception is to be preferred precisely because it *begins from* the desire to explain conventional epistemic practice, rather than from the desire to provide an ultimate grounding and foundation for our conventions, one thought to exist independently of our thought and language (embodied in the notion of an ineffable particular).

However, the mere fact that *prameya* informs the nature of *pramāṇa* need not suggest that our understanding of the nature of those reliable warrants which assure our knowledge of the world is based on reasoning that is viciously circular. Rather, dependence on *prameya* is constitutive of the nature of a *pramāṇa* itself. This is not to say that we somehow “construct” or “create” the world through our use of the reliable warrants we happen to adhere to. Rather, it tells us that the objects of knowledge which constitute our conventional knowledge of the world cannot be thought to exist independently of the reliable warrants which contribute to the nature of such objects. It makes no sense, then, to think that the fact that we cannot ground epistemic principles in a noncircular

manner means that we cannot think of any epistemic system as superior to any other, for we may always allow our understanding of *prameya* to contribute to the decision concerning whether we should sanction a set of epistemic principles which represent the nature of the warrant provided by use of a given set of *pramāṇas*.

My interpretation of the dialogue provides an example of how this may occur. *DP* is inferior to *CP* because it is not sufficiently informed by an understanding of the conventional objects of perception as evidenced in ordinary discourse. In this instance, a penalty for ignoring the conventional objects of perception in determination of one's construal of perception is that one denies an intelligibility prerequisite of ordinary language use and in so doing commits performative contradiction. If the case of perception may be taken as illustrative of a more general principle, then this interpretation suggests that allowing an understanding of the conventional objects of knowledge to influence the determination of the conventional means to knowledge provides a way of assessing the relative merits of any proposed alternative epistemic system.

The relativism implicit in the doctrine of mutual dependence, then, differs markedly from the epistemic relativism considered in this chapter. It is a relativism which denies that all ways of knowing the world are equally valid. Furthermore, the case of perception, if illustrative of a more **(p.241)** general principle, suggests that, in cases where alternative epistemic systems yield conflicting verdicts on the epistemic status of particular knowledge claims, the parties to the dispute need not simply agree to disagree as a matter of course. Rather, the authority of the epistemic systems used to yield the conflicting verdicts might be debated via consideration of whether each system is sufficiently informed by an understanding of those everyday objects of knowledge which constitute our conventional understanding of the world. Though this method may not always provide a way to resolve such disputes, it at least renders the comparison of alternative epistemic systems and the resolution of related disputes a *prima facie* possibility. Rather than amounting to a pernicious relativism which threatens the possibility of rational inquiry, then, this interpretation demonstrates that conventional knowledge, understood as that which exists in virtue of the mutual dependence of *pramāṇa* and *prameya*, encourages us to look toward the shared, intersubjective basis of understanding which is a precondition of rational inquiry. The mutual dependence of convention is, then, that which *allows for* (rather than that which denies) the normativity of knowledge at the conventional level.

It will be recalled that the “anything goes” relativism detailed in section 10.2 is one in which epistemic judgments are relative to the epistemic system an individual happens to accept. I want to stress, in closing, that part of what makes Candrakīrti's relativism different is that it is premised on a recognition of the fact that an individual's adherence to an epistemic system is not something

she can “accept” in any straightforward sense. It is more accurate to say that her use of an epistemic system is likely to be partly constitutive of her ability to participate in an intelligible manner within an epistemic community. That Candrakīrti is suspicious of wholesale²⁸ reform of conventional discourse—of that discourse through which we give voice to the “manifest image”²⁹ of man and the world—should thus not be understood as an expression of the sort of parochialism it might be tempting to ascribe to prescientific thought. Rather, this commitment betrays a recognition of the role of convention in providing a shared normative framework to scaffold rational inquiry.

Notes:

(1) Thanks are due to Dan Arnold, Mario D’Amato, Jay Garfield, Tom Tillemans, Jan Westerhoff, and two anonymous reviewers for valuable feedback; Graham Priest for careful reading of several iterations of this work; and George Duke for unwavering support whilst the thesis (of which this chapter is a part) was written.

(2) For a brief account of the “epistemological turn” in Indian philosophy, see Dreyfus (1997, 15–21).

(3) Though Candrakīrti did not (unlike the Svātantrika Jñānagarbha) use the lexicon of the Buddhist epistemologists as a framework for his own philosophy, he was nonetheless influenced by the new epistemological “grammar” popularized by the likes of Dignāga. For an instructive discussion of this trend, see Eckel (1992, 51–58).

(4) It would be tendentious to assimilate this view with the global antirealism described by Dummett. One reason this is so is that Dummett sees debate between realists and antirealists as hinging upon whether statements in a disputed class have truth conditions which obtain independently of our knowledge of them (verification-transcendence). For the Mādhyamika, verification-transcendence plays no significant explanatory role in the interpretation of metaphysical debates.

(5) Quoted in Tillemans (2011c, 151–152).

(6) I have in mind here the sort of relativist described by Paul Boghossian (2006) and Michael Williams (2007).

(7) Hawthorne here cites Peter Unger and Timothy Williamson with approval.

(8) Having said this, some relativists come closer than others to defending a view of this sort. Goodman, Putnam, and Rorty are all examples; each represents

what Mark Eli Kalderon (2009, 236) describes as the “radical analytic left” of epistemological debate.

(9) I follow Dan Arnold’s (2005a) which corresponds to 55.11 to 75.13 of La Vallée Poussin’s (1913) edition of *Prasannapadā*. Though it is a controversial matter to identify the true historical identity of the interlocutor in question, I follow the lead of Arnold and Mark Siderits in taking Candrakīrti’s interlocutor to be Dignāga. So doing affords a valuable opportunity to consider the dialogue as a critique of an epistemological foundationalism which seeks to ground our everyday knowledge of the world via its causal relation with ultimately existent reals (*svalakṣaṇa*). A useful discussion of this approach can be found in Arnold (2005a, 414–416). Also see Siderits (1981, 121–160), and cf. R. A. F. Thurman (1980, 321–327) and C. W. Huntington (2003).

(10) These are literal renderings of the two terms.

(11) I here follow Arnold’s translation of these two terms. Though I take both “reliable warrant” and “means to knowledge” to represent the sense in which a *pramāṇa* plays both a causal and justificatory role in the determination of knowledge, translating the term as “warrant” (where “warrant” denotes that which serves to grant reliable or formal assurance of a thing) seems better able to capture both senses of the term whilst highlighting the latter, justificatory sense, which will be of particular relevance in the comparative analysis to be undertaken in section 10.2.

(12) *Pramāṇasammucaya* 1.5c–d, see Arnold (2005b, 24) and cf. Hattori (1968, 91).

(13) At times, Arnold describes Dignāga’s *svalakṣaṇa* as a “bare” particular (see, for instance 2005b, 143–174). Throughout this chapter, I translate *svalakṣaṇa* simply as “particular.” It is clear that, for Dignāga, the *svalakṣaṇa* is indeed ineffable. However, describing it as “bare” perhaps suggests that it is lacking in properties altogether, and whilst Dignāga does not hold that anything can be properly predicated of the *svalakṣaṇa*, it seems he *does* want to allow that it has qualities (like being impermanent), but that these themselves are particular and are only in one thing at one time. That is, they are more like tropes than universal properties.

(14) *Pramāṇasammucaya* 1.5c–d, see Richard P. Hayes (1987, 134) and cf. Hattori (1968, 177–179).

(15) This point is pushed in the third part of the dialogue. See Arnold (2005a, 449–461).

(16) This is the example used by both interlocutors.

(17) Note that Candrakīrti takes this to be a problem for his interlocutor, who explicitly claims to be providing an account of “ordinary usage (*vyavahāra*).” See Arnold (2005a, 424).

(18) Indeed, if Candrakīrti was *not* reverting to traditional usage here, it would be difficult to reconcile this quotation with his previous claim that Dignāga’s *non*-concept-laden account of perception is nonsensical. For further discussion see Arnold (2005b, 154).

(19) A similar suggestion concerning the irreducibility of truth to warrant can be found in Horwich (2006).

(20) According to Buddhist teaching, being born into the world (of *samsāra*) is a cause of suffering, not of bliss. Further discussion of this passage can be found in Siderits (1981, 149–150).

(21) We could imagine Candrakīrti’s interlocutor responding here by explaining that his account is, in fact, designed to explain conventional epistemic practice from the perspective of the ultimate; though we talk as if jars and other compound objects are perceptible, in fact this is only so in a manner of speaking which accords with convention. However, as Arnold rightly notes, for this to really be an explanation of conventional epistemic practice, we would need to know that there is such thing as a jar which is *not* literally perceptible, just as we know, in the case of birth, that it is not literally blissful. But conventional epistemic practice simply reflects the view that jars are perceptible, *simpliciter*. It is in this sense that Dignāga’s account is (for Candrakīrti) an inappropriate *explanans* of conventional epistemic practice. See Arnold (2005a, 451n140).

(22) See Arnold (2005a 428, including n. 55, and 448–449, including n. 131; 2005b, 153).

(23) See Arnold (2005a, 440–443). Also refer to the discussion in Siderits (1981, 143).

(24) Cf. Arnold (2005a, 448–449).

(25) This point was informed by personal correspondence with Tom Tillemans.

(26) See Garfield (2006, 480) and cf. Mervyn Sprung (1979, 230).

(27) These three, combined with perception, correspond to the four *pramānas* accepted by the Nyāya. See Arnold (2005a, 462–463).

(28) It is less clear whether Candrakīrti would accept refinement or piecemeal reform of the conventional.

(29) See Wilfred Sellars (1962). Sellars's manifest image of the world is one in which we can distinguish "persons, animals, lower forms of life and 'merely material' things, like rivers and stones" (1962, 46), as well as appeal to agents' reasons for thinking and acting as they do. This circumscription of the manifest image has some affinity with Guy Newlands's description of conventional analysis as that which allows us to "distinguish suffering from happiness, persons from rocks, virtue from nonvirtue" (2010, 59–60). Also common to the framework circumscribed by both Sellars's manifest image and Candrakīrti's account of convention is that the basic objects are things which are perceptible (as opposed to the physicist's subatomic particles and Dignāga's particulars).